

Drugs, alcohol and your work — what our policy means for you

{organisation} has a drug and alcohol policy. This leaflet is a plain-language summary — the full policy is available from {policy owner}, and it is the full policy that applies.

Why we have it. Alcohol, drugs and some medicines can affect judgement, reaction time and coordination. The policy exists to keep you and the people around you safe — it is a safety measure, not a judgement about anyone's private life.

The rules in brief

- Never start work, stay at work or carry out any task while affected by alcohol or drugs.
- No alcohol, illegal drugs or “legal highs” during working hours, including breaks.

Shown when alcohol at work events is authorised:

- Alcohol at authorised work social events is the one exception — and you must be fit for duty at the start of your next working period.

Shown when no alcohol is permitted at work events:

- This includes work social events — {organisation} runs alcohol-free events.
- No illegal drugs on premises, in vehicles or on worksites — at any time.

Shown when safety-critical categories are selected:

- Extra care applies to safety-critical work such as {safety-critical list}. If you do this work, the strictest standard applies — no impairment by any substance, including medication.

Taking medication? Some prescribed and over-the-counter medicines can affect your fitness for work. Check the leaflet that comes with the medicine, ask the pharmacist if unsure, and tell {occupational health, when in use} or your line manager if it could affect you at work — especially before safety-critical work. You never have to say what condition you are being treated for. This includes prescribed medicinal cannabis, which is treated like any other prescription.

“occupational health or” is shown only when occupational health is in use.

Shown when a testing programme is active:

If you are asked to take a test. {organisation} runs a testing programme, carried out by {provider}. If you are asked to provide a sample:

- You will always be told why, and the process will be explained before you decide.
- Samples are sealed in front of you and sent to an accredited laboratory — a screening result is never treated as positive on its own.
- A confirmed result is medically reviewed first, so declared medication and prescriptions are ruled out before anything is reported.
- Refusing a test without a reasonable explanation is treated as seriously as a positive result — you will be reminded of this at the time.

Shown when testing is reserved for the future:

Testing. The policy reserves the right to introduce testing in future. You would be consulted, and told exactly how it works, before any testing started.

Shown when the policy stance is support first:

If you are struggling — say so. Coming forward about an alcohol or drug problem before it comes to light another way is treated as a health matter, not a disciplinary one. You will be offered support and a plan, including free confidential help through the employee assistance programme, and your job is not at risk for asking for help.

“including free confidential help through the employee assistance programme” is shown only when an employee assistance programme is in place.

Shown when the policy stance is zero tolerance:

If you are struggling — say so. {organisation} operates a zero-tolerance policy on breaches, but asking for help is not a breach. Support is available through the free confidential employee assistance programme and coming forward early is always better than a problem surfacing another way.

“through the free confidential employee assistance programme” is shown only when an employee assistance programme is in place.

Questions? Speak to your line manager or {policy owner}. Your information is handled confidentially under data protection law.

This leaflet summarises the {organisation} drug and alcohol policy, version {version}, {date}. It is not the policy itself and is not legal advice. Prepared with NIVHA Laboratory Services.

v1.0 — issued 1 September 2026 · prepared with NIVHA Laboratory Services · a template for the organisation to review and adopt — not legal advice.